

The Art of the Prompt

Day 2 morning · Playful Programming and Artificial Intelligence · University of Copenhagen

THE CHALLENGE — IDENTICAL FOR EVERY PAIR

Task: get the model to explain *photosynthesis* to a bored 15-year-old who loves football and thinks biology is pointless.

Rules: prompt as many times as you like within 20 minutes. Submit your single best output, printed or copied to the wall, along with the prompt that produced it.

Judging: the room votes in three categories — most likely to actually work, most surprising, most absurd.

Step by step

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|---|--------|---|
| 1 | 5 min | First naive attempt. Before any discussion, send one quick prompt and keep the output. It will be competent, generic, and nothing like something a bored 15-year-old would read — that's the baseline. |
| 2 | 20 min | The challenge proper. Start the timer. Iterate freely, no guidance yet. Give the model a role, demand a format, feed it an example, tell it what not to do. |
| 3 | 10 min | Gallery and vote. Best output goes on the wall next to the prompt that produced it. Silent gallery walk, then the three-category vote. |
| 4 | 15 min | Reverse-engineering. Dissect the two or three winning entries publicly. Extract the moves onto the board as the room finds them. |

Reverse-engineering the winners

ROLE

“You are a football commentator” — shifts the whole probability landscape of the continuation.

AUDIENCE MADE CONCRETE

“He supports Brøndby, checks his phone every 40 seconds” — specificity beats adjectives.

CONSTRAINTS

“Under 100 words, no scientific terms without a football comparison” — constraints are creative fuel.

EXAMPLES

“Here is a sentence in the tone I want” — one example outperforms three adjectives.

ITERATION

“That was too childish, keep the jokes but respect his intelligence” — prompting is a dialogue, not a spell.

Facilitation notes

Do not teach prompt patterns up front — independent discovery in Phase 2 is what makes the Phase 4 vocabulary stick.

Keep the audience difficult. An easy audience produces nothing to learn from.

The absurd category is load-bearing — it licenses play and often the strongest technique.

Two-minute warning for over-iterating pairs: pick one, improve it once, submit.

The teacher analogy will surface on its own (“this is just writing a good assignment”) — push on where it fails: the model never tires, never takes offence, has no memory, and complies with a bad brief instead of asking about it.

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PHASE 1 — FIRST NAIVE ATTEMPT

WINNING PROMPT

WINNING OUTPUT

MOST LIKELY TO WORK

MOST SURPRISING

MOST ABSURD